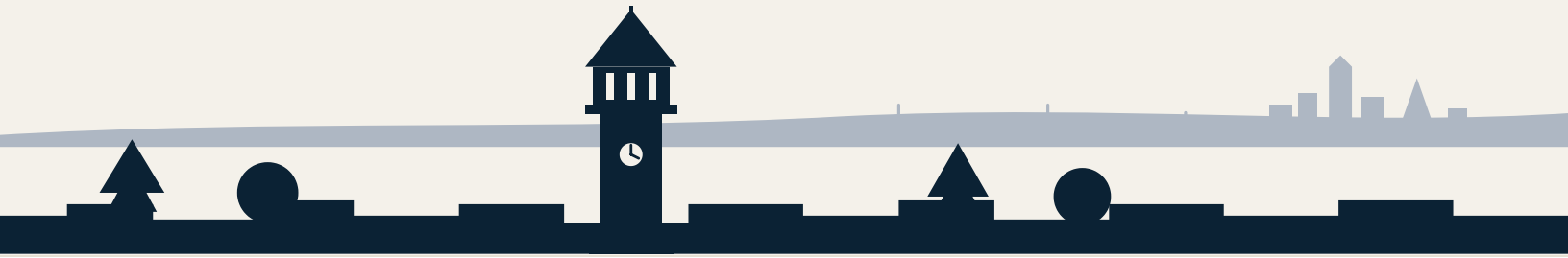
BUYER PLAYBOOK - BERKELEY

What to Know About Home Buying in Berkeley

Across every Berkeley neighborhood, from the flats to the hills, homes move fast and sell over asking. Here is where the market stands right now, and the moves that make your offer the one that gets picked.

$1.64M	128%	14 days
MEDIAN SALE PRICE	SALE TO LIST	ON MARKET

All Berkeley neighborhoods · detached single-family homes · last 12 months. 84% sold over asking, from 593 MLS sales.



1 Do this first, before you buy

- ☑ **Get fully underwritten,** not just pre-approved. This is what lets you safely release the loan contingency and move fast when the right home shows up.
- ☑ **Set aside cash** for a possible appraisal gap and your earnest money, so when it is time to compete, a release never catches you short.

2 How a listing moves

DAYS 1–3

Listing goes live, usually on a Thursday.

TWO WEEKENDS

Back-to-back weekends of open houses.

AROUND DAY 14

Offers due, usually midweek after the second weekend.

You get about two weeks to tour it, read the disclosures, and build your offer. We start prepping yours on day one.

3 Homes are underpriced to attract more buyers (I know, it's annoying)

Homes here are **listed low on purpose** to draw multiple offers, so the list price is bait, not the real number. Last year **84% of Berkeley homes sold over asking**, which is exactly why the list price is not the one that wins. **I run a CMA on every home** so you know its true value and where it is likely to land, and we set your number from that gap between list and sold, not the asking price. The city-wide averages are up at the top of this page.

4 Before you write an offer

- ☑ **Read the seller's disclosure and inspection package** before you write. I turn that packet into a clear, digestible read on what matters, with red flags and likely repair costs called out, so waiving the inspection contingency is informed, not a gamble.

- [x] **Set your number from the CMA.** Your realtor helps guide it based on recent sales for comparable properties, repairs needed, and more.

HOW A HOME SHOULD BE REVIEWED

Before you write, the **disclosure package and the comps both get a full, digestible analysis** through AgentPrep, not a 200-page packet left for you to decode. You will know the home's real condition, the red flags, likely repair costs, and what it should actually sell for. This is the standard every buyer deserves.

> **Bottom line:** A strategy is a critical part of the offer. Going in blind, without a read on recent sales or the listing team's strategy, is a shot in the dark. That won't work, even when you have the highest number but miss the seller's expectations on closing dates, contingency releases, or something else.

5 What a winning offer looks like

Waive the inspection contingency	You have already read the seller's reports, so there are no surprises to fall back on.
Waive the appraisal contingency	If it appraises low, you cover the gap in cash. While this does not happen that often, it is important to be prepared for it just in case. Know that number before you write.
Loan contingency: keep or release	Keeping it is safer; releasing it is stronger. Only release once you are fully underwritten.
Release all contingencies	The most competitive offer there is. Your earnest money, 3% of price, is on the line if you walk.
Close fast: 21 days max	14 to 17 days is ideal. A clean, quick close is often worth more to a seller than a few thousand dollars.

6 Berkeley taxes & point-of-sale items

City transfer tax APPROX

Berkeley charges a city transfer tax at sale, roughly 1.5% up to $1.7M and 2.5% above, plus the county's ~0.11%. Customarily the seller's cost, but offering to cover part of it can make your offer stand out.

Property tax APPROX

Plan for about 1.2% to 1.4% of the purchase price per year, including local assessments. We confirm the exact figure for any home before you offer.

Energy rule (BESO)

Berkeley requires an energy assessment at sale. You will see the home's energy score and recommended upgrades before you close.

berkeleyca.gov/BESO →

Sewer lateral

The private sewer lateral must be certified compliant at sale. We sort out who pays up front.

Usually $6,500–$10,000

Questions on any of this?

Text or call me and I will walk you through it, no pressure.

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